

07-07

Lucy felt a shiver run down her spine. Hastened by Jill, who did not want to be late to her own concert, Lucy hesitantly stepped out of the car and walked toward the school. It was Jill who in her final year of high school had become involved in helping organize this year's school talent show, and she took her

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it wasn't the water snail. It was a large speck of dust that was deceptively bobbing around in the water like a live animal. They were ready to call it quits, when suddenly Mom cried, "Ah ha!" Tucked in a curve of the archway, perfectly hidden against a pitch dark stone, sat Mr. Sticky, safe and sound.

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needed two pieces of paper that were very expensive to draw an elephant, but the teacher didn't mind Abby using the expensive paper because she was pleased with the drawing and wanted it on the wall. The teacher, who was always very encouraging, remarked that the drawing Abby had made was very creative and beamed at Abby, giving her the seal of

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position very seriously. Lucy hurried behind Jill pulling on the worn, oversized coat that had originally belonged to Jill, in order to keep her dry as the raindrops fell all around them. As the sisters entered the hall where the show was to take place, Jill filled with excitement while Lucy regretted that she had promised

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"You, I can always count on." Abby said to her mom, with relief. Then she noticed another water snail was right next to Sticky and asked where this new addition to the family could have come from. "I'm beginning to suspect the pond weed is guilty, don't you think?" replied Mom. They both laughed and climbed into

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approval. Back at home, Mom, convinced by Abby to clean out the tank was cleaning with a special vacuum, or "hoover." "Where's Mr. Sticky?" Abby asked first thing when she came home from school. "On the side," Mom replied. And then she added, "Don't worry I went extra slowly since it's

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her mother she would participate in the show. "To waste your talent would be a real shame, for you have such a beautiful voice," her mother had argued two months back when the concert was first announced. Lucy had been considering it, for she did love to sing. That very night the first text message had come through. "How does it feel to be

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Abby's bed together and though it was cozy, it was a bit of a squeeze. Budge up, Mom said, giving Abby a push with her bottom. "I can't because I'm already on the edge. Good heavens, you've grown then. When did that happen? You could've put an elephant in here last time we did this. Before I know it, you'll be all grown up." On her

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better to be safe than sorry." Abby looked on all sides of the tank but there was no sign of the water snail that she had discovered a couple of days ago. She was very sad. Her Mom said to wait a few hours until the water clears to take another careful look. That evening, Abby went up to her bedroom

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tail and lanky like a giraffe?" it had asked, taking Lucy by surprise. One of the popular girls, Lucy had always known she wasn't, but before the messages began, Lucy had always been quite proud of being a little different. But text by text, Lucy's self confidence had deflated and, in the end, it had taken some doing to

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mom's chest Abby then put her head and smiled.

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to check the tank again. The water had settled and looked clear but Abby could not see Mr. Sticky. Abby kneeled down to have another look in the tank that her Mom had cleared so thoroughly, but Mr. Sticky was still nowhere to be found. Abby was a bundle of nerves as she descended the stairs. In the study surrounded by books and

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get her to agree to perform in the show. Now, however, Lucy had no choice but to make her way towards the stage where Jill was beckoning encouragingly to her. She was the first performer. Lucy, announced by her sister to the audience, was all nerves as she walked out onto the middle of the stage where there was nothing but a

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The text message said that Lucy Josephs was a failure. It said she was ugly, had no style and the world hated her. At least that was what it said to Lucy. It said that and a whole lot more that she was struggling to understand. The actual text of the note said that Lucy better not show up at the party tonight because it was going to be

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papers her mom was working and she looked impatient when she saw Abby in the doorway and even more worried when she heard the bad news. "He'll turn up," Mom said, and that was that. Then, to add fuel to the flames, she raised her tone of voice and said dismissively, "For the time being, go to bed, Abby. I've got masses of work to

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microphone and her. She heard the audience applaud and could feel a sense of anticipation emanate from the other side of the heavy curtain. As the curtains began to part, she cast a worried look at Jill in the wings, who assured her with a positive thumbs up. Lucy thought to herself that she could not go through with this and that she,

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bad enough already! Lucy, who had started receiving these messages a few weeks ago, tapped the mobile screen to make the message disappear from view. She only wished it was as easy to tap her heart and erase the trace the message had left there. "Was that another one of those messages?" her mom asked, who was driving the car.

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catch up on." Abby had a quick temper and she was angry as hell. "You've hovered him up, haven't you?" she said accusingly. Abby's Mom denied Abby's version of the story was true and said that she was careful, but because Mr. Sticky was so small he was hard to see. What's wrong with being small? "Nothing at all, but

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unlike her older sister, was not confident enough to put herself before the judging audience. The crowd looked up at her and Lucy was ready to run when the first notes of the music sounded out and a sudden calm settled over her. She closed her eyes and shut everything out, including the audience, the nerves that threatened to take over, the text

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Lucy confirmed her mother's suspicion was founded as she answered dejectedly, "I'm sorry to say it was." "Haven't you reported it yet?" asked Jill, Lucy's older sister who was sitting in the passenger seat. "Yes," Lucy replied, lying through her teeth. That Lucy should not let the messages get

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it makes things hard to find." "Or notice," Abby said, suddenly feeling like the snail, overlooked Mr. Sticky herself and storming from the room. The door to the bedroom opened a few minutes later and Mom's face appeared. She was there to try to make up for having been insensitive earlier. She had put her work on the back

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messages, and the way they made her feel. It was just her and the music, and it was a love story that had been going on her whole life. She began to sing, and all the pain and confusion that the messages had been causing inside her just flowed out. The words were not important, for it was the feeling behind them that she latched onto. Lucy was in the

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to her and that the sender was only jealous were Lucy's mom's arguments, in an effort to comfort her daughter. Lucy's mom suddenly felt guilty, for she had been the one to buy the phone for Lucy just a couple of months ago. She then admitted her regret about the phone was still bugging her out loud as she sighed, "I never should have

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burner and occupied herself with Sticky. Abby, who was breathing fire all on account of the little snail, tried to ignore her but it was hard when Mom walked over to the bed and sat next to her. Mom, who Abby still strained to remain upset with, had gone out to find her glasses in order to search for Sticky more effectively. "This

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heart of the song with the rest of the world slipping away. When the song finished and the last note died away, she opened her eyes. To see the whole audience on their feet and the hall filled with cheers and applause was not what Lucy had expected. Lucy allowed herself to enjoy the sense of achievement and belonging that she had

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given you that phone Lucy." "No, it's fine, I love it," said Lucy knowing that affording the phone had been no small thing for her mother. It had been nothing but trouble though. Lucy did not know who it was that was sending her the messages, and she did not know how they had got her number, but whoever it was, he or she had slowly taken over

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is my new and extra powerful pair I have for important occasions like snail hunting," she said. She smiled at Abby, trying to butter her up, but Abby didn't smile back. Abby believed her mom's idea would not succeed, but then she had an idea of her own. I've got a magnifying glass, Abby suddenly

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not felt in a very long time. Then she saw her mother, who was cheering the loudest of all in the crowd, and Jill, who was beaming at her with pride from the wings. She knew she owed them big time for reminding her what she was capable of and who she really was. The next time her phone beeped she would tap the message straight into

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Lucy's life. She was getting several texts a day now, all of which were abusive and hurtful. Lucy wondered what the person who was messaging her might be thinking or trying to achieve with all of their hateful messages. As the car pulled up outside the school, which looked like a large shadow in the darkness of a November evening,

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remembered and rushed off to find it. On the floor beside each other they sat, shuffling around the tank, looking all over the place and peering into the corners among the big pebbles and the pondweed. Abby tried to imagine, if she were Sticky, a little water snail, where would she hide out? At one point she thought she saw him, but